She Always Thought She Was a Citizen. Now She Faces a Voting Charge

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-25 5 min read

Marva Cook always believed she was an American citizen. Now, at 66, she has learned otherwise, and she has been charged with voting illegally.

Cook, who lives in Syracuse, New York, was adopted as a toddler. She told Homeland Security investigators earlier this month that she had always assumed she was born in the United States. But while searching for her biological mother, she said, she discovered she had a German birth certificate.

Federal **prosecutors** say Cook has held a **green card** for several years. They say she still cast **ballots** in recent elections even though she was not a citizen. She faces a single federal charge of voting by a noncitizen, tied to her vote in the 2022 **midterm** elections.

Cook turned herself in and appeared in court on Wednesday. She declined to discuss the case, but said the court appearance was difficult and thanked the community members who came to court with her.

The case is one of the latest arrests highlighted by the Trump administration as it searches for noncitizen voters ahead of the **midterms**. The administration says it will not allow citizens' votes to be cancelled out by noncitizens voting illegally. Its own investigations, though, have shown such cases are incredibly rare and have not changed election outcomes.

Cook's supporters describe her very differently. She starred on Syracuse University's women's basketball team decades ago, leading the team in scoring in 1979-80 with 15 points per game, and she holds the school record for steals in a single season.

Today she works as the YMCA's community school program director, supporting low-income families and young people. Her pastor, Fred Daley, said she is an active church member who for years dressed up as the church's Easter Bunny, and a longtime **parishioner** called her a person of service.

Word Treasure

prosecutors -- Lawyers who bring a criminal case against someone on behalf of the government.

ballots -- Votes that people cast in an election, often on paper or a voting form.

midterm -- An election held in the middle of a president's term of office.

green card -- A card showing that a person is allowed to live and work in the United States, though it does not make them a citizen.

parishioner -- A regular member of a local church community.

Background you need

In the United States only citizens may vote in federal elections, while a green card lets a person live and work in the country without making them a citizen.

An adopted child is raised by a family that is different from the family they were born into, so they may not know all the details of their birth.

Midterm elections are elections held in the middle of a president's term, when voters choose members of Congress and other offices.

A community school program works with schools and families to support children and parents, especially those with less money.

Break it down

LEAD: Marva Cook, 66, always believed she was an American citizen, but she has learned otherwise and has been charged with voting illegally.

KEY EVENT: Cook faces a single federal charge of voting by a noncitizen, tied to her vote in the 2022 midterm elections.

+- WHO: Cook, who lives in Syracuse, New York, was adopted as a toddler and holds a green card.

+- WHAT: Prosecutors say she cast ballots in recent elections even though she was not a citizen.

+- WHEN: She turned herself in and appeared in court on Wednesday.

EVIDENCE: While searching for her biological mother, she discovered she had a German birth certificate.

OPEN QUESTION: The case is highlighted by the Trump administration in its search for noncitizen voters, while Cook's supporters describe her as a person of service.

Why it matters

This case shows how a person's citizenship can be uncertain even after a lifetime in a country, and why voting rules and identity records matter for real people, not just in elections.

Test what you remember

1. What did Marva Cook always believe about herself?

- (A) That she was an American citizen
- (B) That she had never voted
- (C) That she was born in Germany
- (D) That she lived in Germany

2. How did Cook discover she had a German birth certificate?

- (A) When she played basketball
- (B) When she applied for a passport
- (C) When she joined the YMCA
- (D) While searching for her biological mother

3. What single federal charge does Cook face?

- (A) Stealing ballots
- (B) Lying to a basketball team
- (C) Voting by a noncitizen, tied to her vote in the 2022 midterm elections
- (D) Working without a green card

4. What have the administration's own investigations shown about noncitizen voting cases?

- (A) They are never investigated
- (B) They are incredibly rare and have not changed election outcomes
- (C) They happen in every election
- (D) They changed the 2022 results

5. What did Cook do at Syracuse University decades ago?

- (A) She starred on the women's basketball team and led it in scoring in 1979-80
- (B) She ran the YMCA
- (C) She coached the men's team
- (D) She worked as a pastor

6. What job does Cook hold today, according to the article?

- (A) Federal prosecutor
- (B) Homeland Security investigator
- (C) YMCA community school program director, supporting low-income families and young people
- (D) University basketball coach

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: C 4: B 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Federal prosecutors: Cook held a green card for several years but still cast ballots in recent elections even though she was not a citizen.

2. The Trump administration: It will not allow citizens' votes to be cancelled out by noncitizens voting illegally.

3. Cook's supporters: She is a person of service: a former Syracuse University basketball star who now supports low-income families and young people, and an active church member.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):